

User Interviews - 2

User insights: The ultimate shortcut to the right requirements.

What we've covered

What are user interviews:

- **Goal-oriented:** Focused on specific research questions and user needs
- **Conversational:** Open-ended questions that invite stories and examples
- **Exploratory:** Discover what you don't know you don't know
- **Qualitative:** Rich context that surveys and analytics can't provide

Planning the Interview

Creating the Interview Questions

What we'll cover next

To turn a raw conversation into a strategic asset, you need a balance of tactical preparation and analytical rigor. User interviews aren't just about asking questions; they are about creating a space where the user feels comfortable enough to reveal their honest friction points.

1. **Preparation** - Setting the Stage.
2. **Execution** - The Art of the Interview.
3. **Synthesis** - Turn raw conversations into patterns.
4. **Structure** - Translate patterns into clear, decision-ready insights.
5. **Share** – Create shared understanding that drives action based on evidence.

Interview Activities

- Day Before
- Day of
 - Pre-Interview Set up
 - Interview
 - Post-Interview
- After
 - Synthesize Findings
 - Structure Findings
 - Share Findings

The Day Before

- Send reminder email to participants.
- Gather all materials (recording devices, release forms, paper, pens, etc.).
- Ensure that the interview space is reserved.
- Practice

The Day of: Pre-Interview Set-up

- Room & materials
- Team alignment (who's doing what: moderator / note-taker)
- Review One-Page Plan
- Script & Consent forms
- Review Questions

The Interview Session

- Preamble
- Welcome & Consent
- Core Interview
- Wrap up

Key Concepts

Context Setting:

- Can you walk me through a typical day?
- Tell me about the last time you [did X].
- What tools or processes do you currently use?

Exploration:

- What's the hardest part about that?
- How do you feel when that happens?
- What does 'good' look like for you?

Probing Deeper:

- Can you tell me more about that?
- Why is that important to you?
- What would you do if that wasn't available?

Avoid These:

- "Would you use a feature that does X?"
- "Don't you think it would be better if...?"
- "Do you like this design?"

Conducting great interviews

Embrace Silence

- Pause after answers. Silence prompts participants to elaborate.

Follow the Thread

- Deviate from script when something interesting emerges.

Take Sparse Notes

- Note key quotes. Don't let note-taking break eye contact.

Always Record

- With consent. Transcripts reveal things you missed live.

No Leading Qs

- "Tell me about X" not "Isn't it hard when X happens?"

Stay Curious

- Treat every answer as a surprise. Don't assume intent.

One Notetaker

- Separate interviewer from notetaker for best results.

Watch the Clock

- Reserve last 10 min for "anything else you'd like to share?"

Post-Interview Download

- **Silent reflection** (each interviewer), 2-3 minutes
 - Top 3 insights
 - Biggest surprise
 - Emotional moments
 - Quotes
- **Verbal Download**, 5-10 minutes
 - Discuss
 - What patterns emerged?
 - What felt emotionally charged?
 - Did anything contradict assumptions?
 - What signals Product Market Fit potential
 - Capture
 - Sticky notes or digital board
 - Label by theme (Planning, budget, loyalty, stress, time, etc.)

Synthesize Findings

As soon as you can after the last interview.

- **Affinity Clustering** (group insights into themes)
 - Planning behaviors
 - Budget anxiety
 - Loyalty usage gaps
 - In-store friction
 - Mental load
 - Analog vs digital split
- **Pattern Identification**
 - Ask:
 - What repeated across 3+ participants?
 - What strong emotion(s) showed up?
 - What workaround behavior is interesting?
 - Where is there real friction vs mild annoyance?
 - Highlight
 - High-frequency pain
 - High-intensity pain
 - Behavior contradictions

Structure Findings

Within 24-48 hours.

1. Research Overview

- Who we spoke with
- How many
- Criteria
- Date

2. Key Behavioral Patterns (not opinions)

- "4 of the 5 participants create lists but modify them heavily in-store."

3. Friction Points

- Rank by:
 - Frequency
 - Emotional intensity
 - Impact on spend or time

4. Opportunity Signals

- Where users said:
 - "I wish..."
 - "I hate..."
 - "I always forget..."
 - "I use three apps because..."

5. Analog vs Digital Differences

6. Loyalty Program Observations

7. Early PMF Signals

Share Findings

Internal Team Debrief (30-60 minutes)

- Structure:
 - Start with quotes (humanize it)
 - Show/share behavioral clips if recorded
 - Present patterns
 - Present tension points
 - Present opportunities
 - Avoid jumping immediately to features
- Ask:
 - What surprised you?
 - What assumptions were wrong?
 - What does this kill?
 - What does this accelerate?

Share Findings

Stakeholder Share-Out (30-45 minutes)

Keep it crisp and behavioral.

- Avoid:
 - "Users want X feature."
- Say:
 - "Users consistently struggle with..."
- Anchor in evidence:
 - Direct quotes
 - Frequency counts
 - Emotional intensity
- End with:
 - Clear next step proposal
 - Clear product implication hypothesis

User interviews turn assumptions into evidence.

Planning and conducting user interviews ensures we deeply understand real behaviors, unmet needs, and decision drivers before building solutions.

- **Product Market Fit** – they help us uncover behavioral truth so we can validate product-market fit before investing in features.
- **Behavioral Lens** – User interviews allow us to observe how people actually think, decide, and act — not how we assume they do.
- **Strategy-Aligned** – Structured user interviews reduce risk by replacing assumptions with evidence-driven insight.

Questions?

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